Master thesis notes

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1 NLO computations in the subtraction scheme

1.1 $q(p_1) + \bar{q}(p_2) \to V + g(p_4)$, V colorless

Consider the production of a lepton pair, by annichilation of a quark and a antiquark. These process are known as DY process. At LO (in α_s), there are two diagrams, when the exchange is mediated by a photon or a Z boson. The amplitude is known. We label p_1 the momentum of the quark, and p_2 of the anti-quark. The two diagrams are in figure 1.1, and we write their amplitudes as

$$\mathcal{M}(1,2) = \delta_{ij}\bar{v}(p_2)\gamma^\mu u(p_1)L_\mu(p_\ell, p_{\bar{\ell}}) \tag{1.1}$$

The function L_μ contains the propagator of the photon/Z boson, as well as the lepton vertex. So we just used the electromagnetic vertex of the quarks.

As is well known, if we have to compute the cross section at NLO, there are two type of corrections we need to compute. Naturally there are the 1 loop diagrams, that are called virtual, because in the sub-process, an off-shell virtual particle is created. Then there are the real diagrams: in those, an extra gluon appears in the final space. This processes are real because in those a real on-shell gluon is created, and in particular the final phase space is different. Real diagrams are tree level: they should be easy, but the integration over the final state gluon gives some trouble.

Let us discuss in detail. In figure 1.2 we've drawn the relevant diagrams, both real and virtual. Let's focus on the real. Their amplitude is obtained by eq. 1.1, by adding the multiplicative factor of the extra color vertex, times the quark propagator, that can take values of $p_1 - p_4$, or $-(p_2 - p_4)$, if p_4 is the momentum of the emitted gluon.

Thus, we write

Figura 1.1: the LO diagrams for DY process

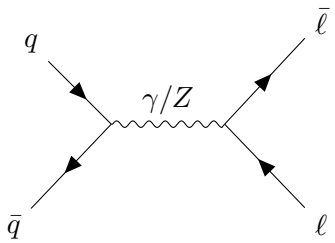
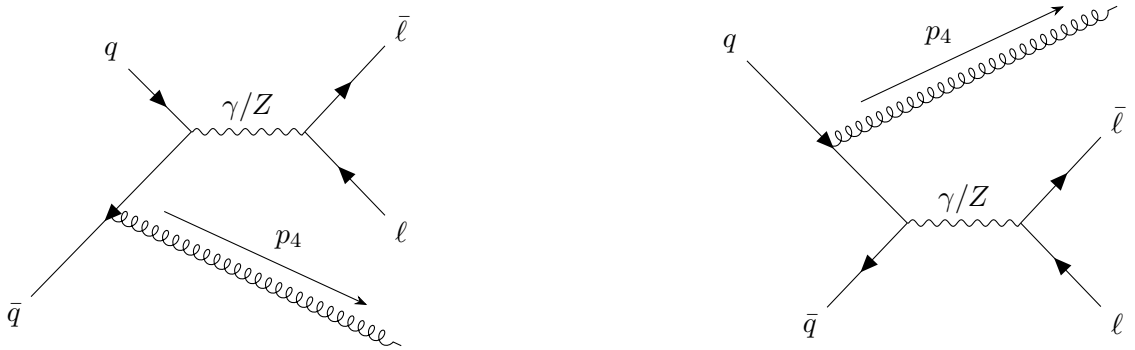


Figura 1.2: NLO diagrams for DY process



$$\mathcal{M}(1,2,4) = \epsilon^*_\nu(p_4) g_{s,b} (T^a)_{ij} \bar{v}(p_2) \left(\gamma^\mu \frac{\not{p}_1 - \not{p}_4}{(p_1 - p_4)^2} \gamma^\nu - \gamma^\nu \frac{\not{p}_2 - \not{p}_4}{(p_2 - p_4)^2} \gamma^\mu \right) u(p_1) L_\mu(p_\ell, p_{\bar{\ell}}) \tag{1.2}$$

To simplify things, we'd like to use Dirac's equation, that tells us $\not{p}_1 u(p_1) = 0 = \bar{v}(p_2)\not{p}_2$ (we will always consider massless quarks). In both cases, we anti-commute with the γ^ν Dirac gamma,

$$\begin{aligned} \not{p}_1 \gamma^\nu u(p_1) &= \left\{ \not{p}_1, \gamma^\nu \right\} u(p_1) = 2 p_1^\nu u(p_1) \\ \bar{v}(p_2) \gamma^\nu \not{p}_2 &= 2 \bar{v}(p_2) p_2^\nu \end{aligned} \tag{1.3}$$

Now consider the "soft" limit, where $E_4 \to 0$: then we can take $\not{p}_4 = 0$ in the numerator. For the denominator instead we use $(p_1 - p_4)^2 = -2p_1 \cdot p_4 = -2E_1 E_4 (1 - \cos\theta_{14}) = -2E_1 E_4 \rho_{14}$. In general, we indicate $\rho_{ij} = (1 - n_i \cdot n_j)$, if n_i are unit vector that point in the same direction as p_i. Therefore $\rho_{ij} \in [0, 2]$, $\forall i, j$.

We define $S_i A := \lim_{E_i \to 0} A$. We find

$$S_4 \mathcal{M}(1,2,4) = g_{s,b} \epsilon^*_\nu(p_4) (T^a)_{ij} \bar{v}(p_2) \left(-\frac{\gamma^\mu p_1^\nu}{E_1 E_4 \rho_{14}} + \frac{\gamma^\mu p_2^\nu}{E_2 E_4 \rho_{24}} \right) u(p_1) L_\mu(p_\ell, p_{\bar{\ell}}) \tag{1.4}$$

squaring this, we can write

$$\begin{aligned} S_4 |\mathcal{M}(1,2,4)|^2 &= -\frac{g_{s,b}^2 (N_c^2 - 1)}{2 N_c E_4^2} \left(-\frac{p_1^\nu}{E_1 \rho_{14}} + \frac{p_2^\nu}{E_2 \rho_{24}} \right)^2 |\mathcal{M}(1,2)|^2 \\ &= 2 \frac{g_{s,b}^2 C_F}{E_4^2} \left(\frac{p_1 \cdot p_2}{E_1 E_2 \rho_{14} \rho_{24}} \right) |\mathcal{M}(1,2)|^2 = 2 \frac{g_{s,b}^2 C_F}{E_4^2} \left(\frac{\rho_{12}}{\rho_{14} \rho_{24}} \right) |\mathcal{M}(1,2)|^2 \end{aligned} \tag{1.5}$$

In the first line, the factor $N_c^2 - 1$ comes from $\mathrm{Tr}(T^a T^a) = \frac{1}{2}\delta^{aa} = \frac{N_c^2 - 1}{2}$, and the factor $N_c^- 1$ is the color factor of $|\mathcal{M}(1,2)|^2$. Thus we see $C_F = \frac{N_c^2 - 1}{2 N_c}$ appearing naturally. This is the known factorization of the matrix element in the soft limit, and the factor before $|\mathcal{M}(1,2)|^2$ is called *eikonal* factor. In can be shown that this is happens universally, not only for DY process.

Now that we have properly obtained the eikonal factor, we see that its integral over the gluon finale phase space is not finite. Of course this is a problem: we cannot, for example, put the integral in a MC program and get a sensibile result.

To see how the problem can be resolved, first we introduce some useful notation. We also switch to the more general case where the process is $q\bar{q} \to V + g$, with V colorless particles. We denote the contribution of the real diagrams of $d\sigma^{NLO}$ as

$$d\sigma^R = \frac{1}{2s} \int [dg_4] F_{LM}(1,2,4) \tag{1.6}$$

where $(2s)^{-1}$ is the flux factor, $[dg_4] = \frac{d^{d-1}p_4 \theta(E_{max} - E_4)}{(2\pi)^d 2E_4}$ and

$$F_{LM}(1,2,4) = d\text{Lips}_V |\mathcal{M}(1,2,4)|^2 \mathcal{F}_{kin}(1,2,4) \tag{1.7}$$

where $d\text{Lips}_V$ is the lorentz invariant phase space of the particles V, and $\mathcal{F}_{kin}(1,2,4)$ is a IR safe observable.

Now notice that the soft limit is not the only point in the phase space that is not integrable. There is also the so called *collinear* singularity, that arises if θ_{14} or θ_{24} vanishes (or, equivalently, ρ_{12} or ρ_{14} go to 0).